🌺 Poinsettias: Reading

Horticulture 1 · Unit 8 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Unit 13 Questions, care chart, pests, lab report, Poinsettia Portfolio, quizzes

Name: _____

Growing Poinsettias

Poinsettias are native to Mexico and were brought to the United States in the 1820s by Joel Poinsett. Today they are the top-selling potted flowering plant in the country, with most sold in November and December. Growers start them from cuttings in summer so every plant in a crop is identical.

The colorful parts of a poinsettia are not petals. They are bracts, modified leaves that turn red, pink, white or marbled. The true flowers, called cyathia, are the small yellow structures in the center. Buyers look for cyathia that have not yet shed pollen, a sign that the plant is fresh.

Poinsettias are short-day plants. Their bracts color only when they receive long, uninterrupted nights of about 14 hours of darkness for several weeks, starting in late September or early October. Even light from a street lamp can keep them green. Photoperiod is the length of the light period in a day.

Good care keeps poinsettias healthy. Water the soil when the surface feels dry and keep water off the leaves, because wet foliage invites botrytis, a gray mold. Overwatering causes root rot. Common pests include whiteflies, mealybugs and mites. The milky sap can irritate skin and eyes and is a concern for people with latex allergies, so wear nitrile gloves. Pesticides and growth regulators are applied only by staff. At the sale, plants are sleeved to protect them from cold and damage.

Check your reading

1. Explain why a poinsettia's red parts are not flowers.

2. What does short-day plant mean for a grower?

3. Name two care mistakes and the problem each causes.